Who Represents the Destination, and What Do They Evaluate? Social-Media Posts about Qingdao

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Abstract. ~~Destination marketers and researchers frequently interpret social-media posts~~ Social-media posts are often read as direct proxies for ~~the destination imageheld by tourists. Conceptualizing~~ tourists' destination image. Treating posts as produced discourse rather than static cognitive images, ~~this extended abstract examines~~ we examine how institutional accounts and individual creators portray a single destination, Qingdao. ~~We cleaned 19, 099 posts and retained~~ After cleaning, 10,178 ~~for formal use on four platforms,after low-quality Bilibili posts were dropped~~of 11,599 Qingdao tourism-related posts from four platforms were retained as destination-relevant. In a pilot ~~analysis~~ of 100 posts (476 segments), practical trip-planning information ~~predominated~~ (58% of segments) ~~, whereas~~ outweighed affective and sensory ~~expressions were less frequent~~ expression (30%). ~~Evaluations of core attractions were overwhelmingly favourable~~ Core attractions were evaluated overwhelmingly favourably (155 of 166 evaluations), whereas operational ~~aspects—price~~aspects (price, service, accessibility, and ~~crowding—were evenly divided~~ crowding) were evenly split (20 favourable vs. 19 unfavourable). ~~The subsequent stage investigates whether institutional and individual creator groups project divergent destination images from identical resources.~~

Keywords: destination image · user-generated content · content creators · content analysis.

1 Background

Destination image ~~comprises the cumulative beliefs and impressions an individual holds about a place, which cannot be reduced to simple aggregate content frequencies [6] . While~~ is an interactive system of thoughts, opinions, feelings, visualizations, and intentions toward a destination [6], which content frequency counts capture only in part. Image forms through induced, autonomous, and organic information agents [2]; social-media ~~posts provide foundational material for image formation [2]~~posts now act as such agents and can be coded for cognitive and affective attributes [1], but an online post is not ~~identical~~ equivalent to the internal ~~cognitive image held by a visitor . Prior research contrasting official marketing~~ image a visitor holds. Studies such as [5] compare official marketing (projected image) with tourist-generated content ~~has largely focused on thematic presence via word-frequency metrics [5]. Consequently, less~~ (perceived image) by the themes each contains. Less is known about ~~discursive variations in how destinations are represented: what pragmatic~~ the functions a post ~~serves~~performs, which attributes it evaluates, and how creator identity shapes ~~the narrative~~both.

2 Purpose

This study investigates We compare how institutional accounts and individual creators represent Qingdaoby examining : their communicative strategies, the specific resources and attributes evaluated, and their co-occurrence within discrete text they evaluate, and how these co-occur within segments. We hypothesize that, even when depicting identical destination the same resources, institutional posts consistently lean toward uncritical, promotionalrepresentationstay uncritically promotional, whereas individual creators temper generally positive accounts with pragmatic balance positive portrayals with practical caveats, critiques, or advice.

3 Method

We employedtheory-driven structured content analysis [3]. Segments are produced by semantic segmentation of the post text, and each segment is coded for rhetorical [4]. Before coding, each post was divided into self-contained units of meaning by embedding-based semantic segmentation (Qwen3-Embedding-8B) under fixed boundary rules; coders did not alter the boundaries. Each segment was coded for communicative strategy, target destination resource, evaluative attribute, and the evaluative valence and intensityof the evaluation. Account metadata are catalogued independently of textual codes, and creator . Creator grouping criteria were pre-registered before inspecting comparative group outcomes. Trained fixed before any group comparison. Cleaning used a relevance classifier trained on 1,300 annotated posts, the cleaning model retained 10,178 posts for formal use on four platforms, after low-quality Bilibili posts were dropped. The pilot sample was coded independently by two trained human coders (inter-coder reliability for evaluative directionreached Cohen's $\kappa = 0.82$), with discrepancies resolved through consensus discussions to establish the final labelsmanually labelled posts. Two coders independently coded the pilot (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.82$, evaluative direction) and discussed disagreements.

4 Results to Date

Filtering destination-relevant content. Of 19,099 cleaned posts, 10,178 on four platforms were retained for formal use after low-quality Bilibili posts were dropped. Keyword-matched counts therefore overstate the posts actually used.

What posts do. The pilot sample covers In the 100 randomly sampled posts across pilot posts (476 segments. Practical), practical information (itineraries, pricing, how-to advice) appears in 58% of segments, sensory or emotional rendering expression in 30%, background knowledge in 11%, and calls for interaction in 3%. Approximately About half of the posts convey give explicit recommendations.

What posts ~~judge~~evaluate. ~~The two human coders concurred on both the target attribute and evaluative valence across~~ Of the 216 evaluations ~~. Core~~ on which both coders agreed, core attraction quality, activities, and destination atmosphere accounted for 166 ~~evaluations~~ (155 favourable vs. 10 unfavourable). ~~Conversely~~By contrast, operational factors—price, service, facilities, accessibility, crowding, and management—accounted for 44~~evaluations, with sentiment~~ , evenly split (20 favourable vs. 19 unfavourable).

~~*Where categories blur.* The coders diverged most frequently on whether visiting a landmark constitutes an activity versus a sight, and whether specific architectural structures function as scenic sights or service facilities. Consequently, the refined coding codebook explicitly separates scenic architectural attractions from functional hospitality facilities.~~

5 Significance

~~For~~ Positive evaluations centred on core attractions, whereas negative ones concentrated on manageable operational aspects, so the actionable signal for destination marketing organizations (DMOs) ~~, this pilot untangles critical operational nuances that~~ lies in roughly one-fifth of evaluations, which aggregate sentiment scores obscure. ~~Favourable evaluations predominantly attach to endowed destination assets, whereas complaints concentrate on manageable operational touchpoints; thus, actionable managerial signals reside within roughly one-fifth of all evaluations. Furthermore, posts function predominantly as pragmatic travel-planning utilities rather than purely affective personal reflections. If subsequent full-sample analysis confirms that individual creators absorb and project operational critiques while institutional accounts omit them, the two cohorts effectively construct divergent destinations from the same underlying resources. Aligned~~ In line with the conference theme ~~of Hype and Return, our methodology demonstrates where computational automation delivers efficiency and where rigorous human discernment remains indispensable.~~ (*Shaping Tourism Technology: Hype, Human Centricity and ROI*), our workflow leaves high-volume filtering and segmentation to models and interpretive judgement to human coders. Sentiment reports by attribute and creator type would show DMOs where operational investment pays off.

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